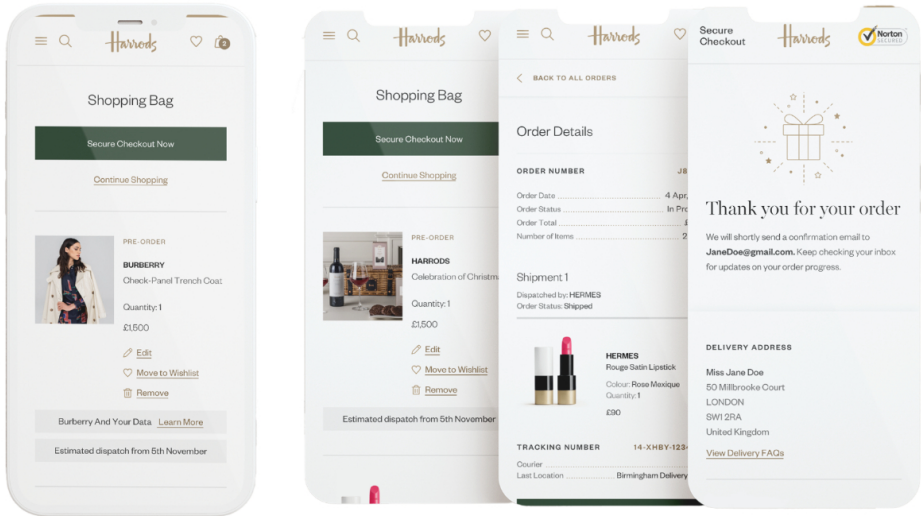




Harrods Pre-order Feature Design

Role

UI/UX Designer

Duration

8 weeks

Team

Solo Designer

The Challenge

"I missed out on the limited-edition bag I wanted because I didn't know when it would be available. By the time I heard about it, everything was sold out. There should be a way to reserve items in advance."

— Emma Thompson, Luxury Shopper

Harrods did not offer a pre-order feature across its website or mobile app. Through early analysis, I identified this as a key cause of customer frustration and lost revenue, particularly for high-demand and limited-edition products.

The challenge was to design a pre-order experience that felt **effortless, exclusive, and premium**, while also giving Harrods clearer insight into customer demand and purchasing intent.

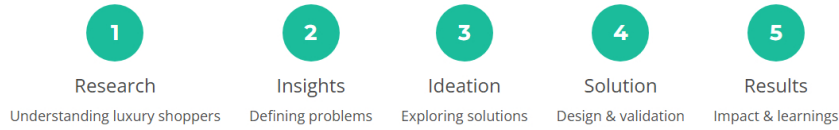
The Problem I Identified

- Customers frequently missed high-demand items due to lack of early access
- There was no digital mechanism to capture demand before product launch
- Customers were forced to repeatedly check availability, creating frustration
- Missed conversion opportunities reduced both revenue and customer satisfaction

Solution Approach I Developed

I designed and tested a complete **pre-order feature** that allows customers to reserve products before they are officially available. The solution improves the luxury shopping experience while enabling Harrods to forecast demand more accurately and manage inventory more effectively.

Design Process



1 Research: Understanding Luxury Shopping Behaviour

What I needed to discover: I needed to understand how luxury shoppers perceive early access, exclusivity, and convenience—especially for limited releases—and how these expectations align with Harrods' brand positioning.

I also explored how a pre-order feature could deliver business value without compromising the premium experience customers expect.

"Luxury shopping should be effortless and exclusive. When I want something, I expect access before everyone else. That's part of what I'm paying for."

— Victoria Sterling, VIP Customer

Research Approach

I structured my research to balance **customer expectations, competitive standards, and business goals.**

Customer Surveys & Interviews: I gathered insights from Harrods customers across different segments to understand expectations around exclusivity and early access.

User Journey Analysis: I mapped journeys for limited-edition purchases to identify friction points and moments of frustration.

Competitive Analysis: I analysed how other luxury retailers approached pre-ordering to identify best practices and opportunities for differentiation.

Business Impact Assessment: I evaluated how pre-ordering could support inventory planning, revenue forecasting, and customer loyalty.

Research Synthesis

I documented key findings through stakeholder interview summaries and competitive analysis frameworks to guide design decisions.

Competitive analysis

	Pre-Order Functionality	Strengths	Weaknesses
Net A Porter	Clearly marked "Pre-Order" on product pages. - Estimated delivery date displayed. - Option to choose notification reminder for alerts. - Seamless integration into shopping cart.	Limited pre-order window information (e.g., closing date). - No visual distinction for pre-order items in search results.	Clear communication is key. Include pre-order window details and potential delays. - Consider highlighting pre-order items for better discoverability.
Harvey Nichols	"Pre-Order Now" button with estimated arrival date. - Pre-order confirmation email with order details.	Limited information on pre-order window (e.g., closing date). - No visual distinction for pre-order items in search results.	Provide more details about pre-order window availability. - Implement visual cues to identify pre-order items in search and browsing.
Selfridges	"Coming Soon" badge with estimated arrival date. - Option to "Register interest" for email notifications. - Pre-order items displayed in a dedicated "Coming Soon" section.	Lacks clear distinction between "Coming Soon" pre-order and general upcoming arrivals. - "Register interest" doesn't guarantee purchase opportunity.	Develop a clear visual hierarchy to differentiate pre-order from general "Coming Soon" items. - Consider offering an option to add pre-order items directly to wishlist for easier future purchase.

Customer interview report

Topic	Key Findings	Recommendations
1. Product discovery	Customers struggle to find pre-order items.	Improve search filters and navigation.
2. Pre-order process	Confusion over delivery dates and availability.	Clarify communication and provide real-time updates.
3. Payment options	Limited payment methods for pre-orders.	Offer flexible payment options.
4. Post-purchase experience	Lack of communication during the wait.	Implement proactive email updates.

Important Finding #1

Customers wanted guaranteed access to limited releases without the stress and uncertainty of launch-day competition.

Important Finding #2

Pre-ordering removed the need to constantly monitor availability, significantly reducing frustration.

Important Finding #3

High-value customers appreciated the ability to plan and budget for luxury purchases in advance.

2 Insights: Defining the Luxury Experience Challenge

What I needed to solve: I synthesised research insights to define a design challenge centred on **security, simplicity, and exclusivity**.

The solution needed to feel like a **service**, not just a transactional feature, while remaining consistent with Harrods' luxury positioning.

Design Questions

- How might I help customers secure high-demand items in advance while preserving the premium Harrods experience?
- How might pre-ordering feel seamless and luxurious rather than transactional?
- How might missed purchase opportunities for limited products be reduced?
- How might pre-order data be used to improve inventory planning and customer satisfaction?

Problem Statement

Based on research, I defined the core problem as a lack of early access and transparency for high-intent customers. Clarifying this challenge allowed me to align design decisions with Harrods' promise of exclusivity while delivering value for both customers and the business. I created a focused user persona to anchor decisions around high-value luxury shoppers.



3 Ideation: From Problems to Elegant Solutions

How I explored solutions: I generated multiple concepts using structured ideation techniques, then evaluated and prioritised them based on user impact, feasibility, and luxury experience standards.

My goal was to reduce effort and uncertainty without adding unnecessary complexity.

Concept Exploration Process

Using Crazy 8s and rapid sketching, I explored different approaches to reserving products. I then used a value vs. effort matrix to prioritise concepts that enhanced exclusivity while integrating smoothly into existing shopping flows.

Concept Sketches

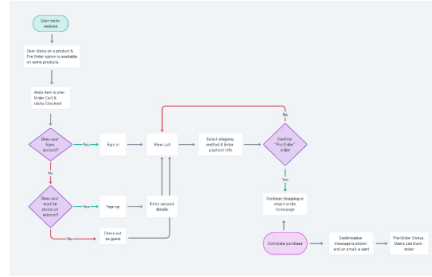
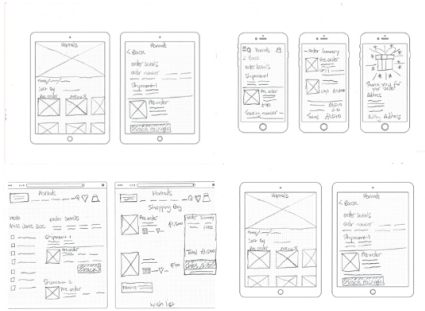
User Flow Design

I designed detailed user flows to ensure the pre-order journey felt familiar, predictable, and frictionless. These flows integrated naturally into Harrods' existing experience rather than introducing a separate or disruptive process.

User Flow

I documented the ideation process to show concept evolution and decision rationale for stakeholder alignment.

I documented detailed flows to guide development priorities and ensure seamless user experience.

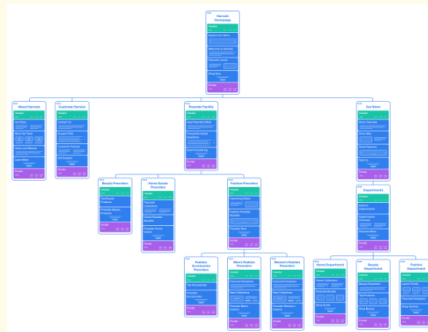


Core Features I Prioritised

- **Exclusive Access Notifications**
VIP-style alerts for upcoming limited releases
- **Seamless Reservation Process**
Clear pre-order flow with transparent delivery expectations
- **Order Status Tracking**
Real-time updates on reservation and fulfilment
- **Flexible Payment Options**
Options for holding or paying in full
- **Wishlist Integration**
Save upcoming products for future pre-orders
- **Concierge Support**
Direct access to personal shopping assistance

Information Architecture

I designed the information architecture to integrate the pre-order feature seamlessly into Harrods' existing platform, ensuring intuitive navigation and minimal cognitive load.



4 Solution: Design & Validation

How my solution came to life: I evolved concepts through iterative design and testing, creating a mobile-first experience that balanced luxury aesthetics with clarity and usability.

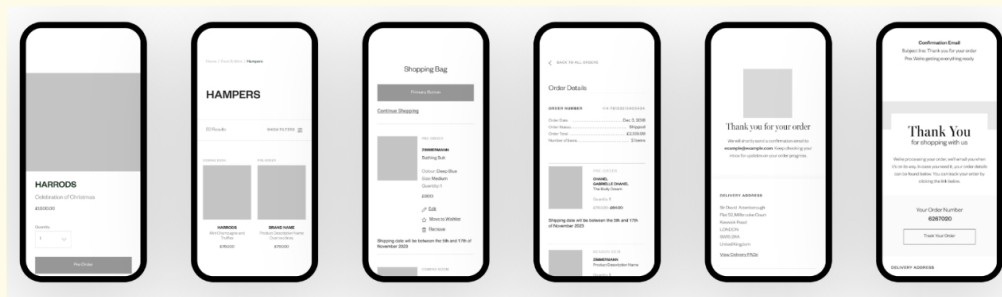
Every design decision aligned with Harrods' brand standards and user expectations.

Design Evolution Process

I began with low-fidelity wireframes to validate core flows and information hierarchy before progressing into high-fidelity designs that reflected Harrods' visual language.

Wireframes

I created progressive wireframes to test core concepts and user flows before investing in high-fidelity design work, ensuring the foundation was solid before adding luxury polish.

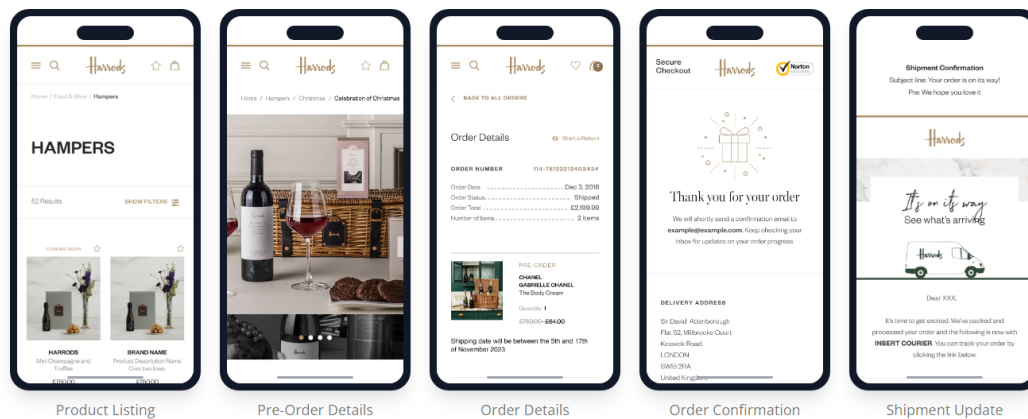


Final Design Solution

I delivered a complete mobile experience covering the end-to-end pre-order journey—from product discovery to shipment confirmation—ensuring consistency, clarity, and polish across all touchpoints.

High-Fidelity Mobile Experience

I created a complete mobile experience that demonstrated the end-to-end pre-order journey, from product discovery to shipment confirmation.



What I Validated

- 100% task completion across all test users
- Feedback consistently described the experience as "intuitive" and "premium"
- Clear understanding of pre-order terms and delivery timelines
- Seamless integration with the existing Harrods shopping experience

Improvements I Made

- Simplified product detail layouts
- Strengthened visual hierarchy for key CTAs
- Refined notification preferences and timing
- Clarified payment options and terminology

5 Results: Impact & Next Steps

What I achieved: I designed a luxury-grade pre-order experience that addressed customer frustration while unlocking opportunities for demand forecasting and conversion optimisation.

This project demonstrated how UX design can enhance exclusivity while delivering tangible business value.

This project demonstrated how UX design can enhance existing, while generating tangible business value.

Key Learnings from This Project

Luxury Requires Simplicity

Premium experiences feel effortless when unnecessary complexity is removed.

Early Access Drives Loyalty

Providing customers with early access strengthens emotional connection and repeat engagement.

Transparency Builds Trust

Clear expectations increase confidence and conversion.

Next Steps I Recommended

- Launch a pilot with a select product category
- Track conversion rates and demand-forecast accuracy
- A/B test messaging and flow variations
- Expand the feature to desktop and in-store kiosks

Final Reflection

Through the Harrods pre-order feature, I demonstrated how strategic UX design can enhance luxury retail experiences while delivering real business value. By focusing on customer empowerment rather than transaction speed, I designed a service that reinforces Harrods' commitment to exclusivity and care.

The most validating feedback came from a user who said:

"This is exactly what luxury shopping should feel like—effortless and exclusive."

This project reinforced my belief that great UX design sits at the intersection of customer desire and business strategy.

